

A

Common uncountable nouns

One of the problems with uncountable nouns is that many of them are countable in other languages.

Common mistakes

I need information. (NOT I need ~~an~~ information.) (no indefinite article)

I need some information. (NOT I need ~~informations~~.) (no plural form)

The homework was difficult. (NOT The homework ~~were~~ difficult.) (use with a singular verb)

- You can put all that **rubbish** in the bin over there. [things that you throw away because you do not want them]
- Is there any more **news** about the man who was injured?
- She gave me some good **advice** about buying a car. [what you think someone should do]
- Do the children get **pocket money** [money that parents give regularly to their children]?
- You need a lot of **equipment** for camping, e.g. tent, sleeping bag, torch, things for cooking, etc. [the things that are used for a particular activity]
- We sold the **furniture** [tables, chairs, armchairs, etc.].
- The **scenery** is really beautiful. [the natural beauty you see around you]
- My **knowledge of** Russian is limited. [what I know about it]
- She's worked very hard and I believe she is **making progress** [improving / getting better].
- Can you take the dog? We haven't got any **room** in our car. [empty space]
- Would anyone like some more **toast**?
- The children's **behaviour** was terrible: they were climbing all over the furniture and making a lot of noise. [the way you do and say things]



bin

tent



sleeping bag



torch



toast



B

Uncountable nouns in dictionaries

Dictionaries show countable nouns with a (C) and uncountable nouns with a (U). Some nouns can be countable with one meaning, and uncountable with another.

experience (U) [the knowledge you get from doing a particular job or activity]

She's got a lot of **experience of** working with children.

experience (C) [something that happens to you that affects the way you feel]

I had so many fantastic **experiences** on my trip to Thailand and Japan.

chance (U) [luck]

Lotto is a game of **chance**.

chance (C) [the opportunity to do something]

He's had several **chances** to go abroad, but he's just not interested.

C

Making uncountable nouns countable

You can make some uncountable nouns singular. Sometimes we do this with a word like **piece** (for advice, equipment, toast, furniture, news), but in spoken English we often use **a bit** (*informal*) with most uncountable nouns.

a good **piece of** advice

an interesting **bit of** news

another **piece of** toast

just **a bit of** rubbish